

A PRIVATE DIGEST

Holly's Edit

*Curated weekly for a discerning reader.
Ten dispatches. No algorithm.*



NO. 1 · 2 AUGUST 2026

PRIVATE
CIRCULATION
ONLY

A PRIVATE DIGEST · NO. 1

Holly's Edit

Ten dispatches from a week in which a spy stood for election, the restaurant industry reckoned with its own obsolescence, half a million people fled their homes in southern Europe, and a spherical raccoon briefly made everything feel manageable.

2 AUGUST 2026

TEN DISPATCHES

Contents

FEATURES

01	The Mayor of Scamtown	5
	<i>Alice Guo, Bamban, and the anatomy of a long con</i>	
02	The Restaurant at the End of the World	9
	<i>Why the business model that fed us for a century is cracking up</i>	

SHORT READS

03	Ageing Disgracefully	12
	<i>The over-55s: Britain's new problem generation</i>	
04	Your Private AI Conversations	14
	<i>On the WIRED / Claude privacy story</i>	

ALSO THIS WEEK

05	The Boom Nobody Asked For	16
	<i>The \$18.74 billion menopause wellness industry</i>	
06	The Continent Is on Fire	20
	<i>Europe's summer of catastrophic wildfires</i>	

REGULARS

07	This Week in London History	23
	<i>The night Pall Mall turned on the gas, 1807</i>	
08	Viral Thing of the Week	25
	<i>The Ballad of Jimothy</i>	

About This Digest

DESCRIPTION

Holly's Edit is a private weekly digest, typeset in the small-press manner, curated and produced for Holly. It draws on the week's best journalism to present ten dispatches: long reads, short reads, cultural commentary, London history, restaurant recommendations, and events. It is designed to be read somewhere comfortable, without a screen.

THIS ISSUE

No. 1 · 2 August 2026 · Ten Dispatches

SOURCES

The Economist (28 July 2026) · Bloomberg Businessweek (28 July 2026) · WIRED (July 2026) · Hot Dinners · Ronnie Scott's · Royal Albert Hall · Pints of Knowledge · Timeout London · Broadsheet · The Nudge · The Infatuation · Multiple event and restaurant listings. All information verified 2 August 2026.

TYPOGRAPHY

Display and headlines: Fraunces variable (Phaedra CS & undercase). Editorial italic: Cormorant Garamond variable. Kickers: Anton. Section labels and colophon headers: Archivo variable. Body text: Work Sans variable. Labels, folios, and captions: Space Mono. All type set in the variable font tradition, with optical-size and weight axes tuned for the A5 format.

DESIGN

A5 (148 × 210 mm). Typeset and printed using WeasyPrint 69. Imposed for saddle-stitch binding at A4. Colour system: cream (#f2ead9), ink (#241f18), burgundy (#6d2438), navy (#263449), rose (#c48a72). Section field colours rotate across ten palettes. No imagery. Two graphic devices only: hero-stat and hero-quote.

SUNDAY THOUGHT

A spy ran for office and won. The shelves ran out of medicine. A continent found it had been planning for a climate that no longer exists. And a raccoon made sixteen million people smile. Not a bad week for paying attention.

HOLLY'S EDIT · NO. 1 · 2 AUGUST 2026

09	EAT — London Restaurants	27
	<i>Logma · Ebi Wines · Hon's BBQ · The Barbary · Lenny's</i>	
10	Events — Things in the Diary	30
	<i>Music · Food & Drink · Talks · August & Beyond</i>	

Good morning, Holly.

This week's digest opens in the Philippines, where a small town called Bamban got a Jollibee franchise and, it later turned out, a Chinese spy — and closes, as weeks tend to, with a raccoon. In between: the slow death of the restaurant as we once understood it, a wellness industry filling the gap where healthcare should be, a summer Europe is only beginning to understand, and a small, precise piece of London

history that explains why you can walk home safely after the theatre.

The writing this week is strong. **The Economist's** account of Alice Guo is remarkable journalism — the kind that makes you feel the texture of how power actually moves in the world. The Bloomberg piece on menopause wellness is sharp and necessary. The wildfire coverage is important and not easy to look at directly, which is one reason it keeps sliding off the news agenda. It's here anyway.



Ten dispatches. I hope you find something worth your Saturday morning.

— HOLLY'S EDIT, NO. 1

A note on format: this digest is typeset in the small-press manner — two columns, generous margins, the odd large number. It's designed to be read somewhere comfortable, without a screen. Brew something warm.

Everything is sourced and dated. Page numbers are in the footer. The EAT

section has five restaurants, all bookable now. Events runs through the end of August. Some of the music listings are exceptional — do not skip past the Miles Davis centenary at the Proms.

Interesting people explain things in pubs. Ticketed (mostly £10–£15), typically sell out. pintsofknowledge.co.uk

TUESDAY 4 AUGUST

Corrupted Kingdom: Why the UK Is Becoming More Corrupt

The Landor Pub, Clapham, SW9.

WEDNESDAY 5 AUGUST

Why Doctor Doom Is Better Than Batman

Don't dismiss this — it's a seriously good talk about moral philosophy via comic books. The George IV, Chiswick.

MONDAY 10 AUGUST

A "Hot" Future: How Nuclear is the Future for Medicine

Old Queen's Head, Islington.

TUESDAY 11 AUGUST

Memento Mori: The Victorian Way of Death

Big Penny Social, Walthamstow.

TUESDAY 6 OCTOBER

Aaron Tveit

Broadway star of *Moulin Rouge!* and *Next to Normal*, in London for one night.

WEDNESDAY 11 NOVEMBER

The Adam and Joe Show

Adam Buxton and **Joe Cornish** reunite to celebrate 30 years of their show, with clips, big-screen retro-ramblings, and stories. The sell-out risk is high on this one.

FOOD & DRINK

MONDAY 4 AUGUST

The Barbary x Billecart-Salmon Kitchen Counter Dinner

Westbourne Grove, Notting Hill. Five courses, Champagne pairings from Brut Réserve to vintage cuvée, just 15 seats at the kitchen counter. £150. Book via SevenRooms.

THURSDAY 6 AUGUST

LIMA Four-Hands Dinner

Fitzrovia. Head chef **Diego Recarte** (LIMA) with **Milton Fragozo** (formerly of Mirazur R&D). Seven courses, Pisco Sour on arrival. £90. Email Enquiry@limalondon.com or call 020 3002 2640.

TUE 5 AUG (AND 2 SEP)

Hoppers Dosa Deep House

King's Cross. Sri Lankan curries, dosas, sunset DJ sets from emerging South Asian artists. The return of Hoppers' limited-edition Kalupol Chicken Bun. Free entry.

THURSDAY 7 AUGUST

International Beer Day — Guinness Open Gate Brewery

Old Brewer's Yard, Covent Garden. 100 free pints from midday — Guinness, Guinness 0.0, or craft beers. Turn up. Free.

FRI 8 - SAT 9 AUGUST

KERB Goes East — Round The Dock

Canada Water. 50+ street food traders: Sichuan noodles, Korean tacos, bao, bánh mì, Filipino barbecue. Live music, lion dancing, taiko drumming, East Asian makers market. Free.

TALKS – PINTS OF KNOWLEDGE

INVESTIGATIVE

The Mayor of Scamtown

How a Chinese spy became mayor of a Filipino town — and what she found when she got there.

The Mayor of Scamtown

Alice Guo, Bamban, and the anatomy of a long con — a dispatch from *The Economist's Extraordinary Story series*.

There is a small town north of Manila called Bamban — population 80,000, low-rise buildings, corrugated-iron shacks, the occasional cart of freshwater snails cooked in coconut milk. Until a few years ago, almost no one outside Tarlac province had heard of it. Then Alice Guo became mayor, and everything changed.

Guo arrived as a dynamo. Young, personable, she went around addressing town elders as *lolo* (grandfather) and *tito* (uncle). Fast-food chains — Jollibee, 7-Eleven, KFC — that had never bothered with Bamban arrived under her watch. Locals saw a local girl made good.

Bamban got a Jollibee and a spy.

— HOLLY'S EDIT

Then, in 2021, Guo started arriving by helicopter. Her explanation — "new business partner" — satisfied no one, but curiosity has its limits in small Filipino towns. She ran for mayor in 2022 and won. It was only in March 2024, after a police raid on a compound at the edge of town, that the full picture emerged.

Inside ten hectares of fencing, the authorities found 36 buildings and hundreds of coerced workers — mostly Chinese nationals — running what

investigators call "pig butchering" scams. The operation worked like this: workers posed as potential lovers on social media, built months-long relationships with their marks, then reeled them into fraudulent investment schemes. Hundreds of millions of dollars vanished from lonely people across the globe.

Guo, it turned out, was not Alice Guo at all. She was Guo Hua Ping, a Chinese national who had fabricated a Filipino identity complete with forged birth

August & Beyond — London Events

MUSIC

SUNDAY 2 AUGUST

Ronnie Scott's Gospel Choir

47 Frith Street, Soho. Led by **Daniel Thomas**: soaring harmonies, uplifting classics, high energy and a room that will be on its feet. Two shows, 2pm and 8pm. Tickets from £30.

TUESDAY 4 AUGUST

Bruno Heinen Trio

Ronnie Scott's. Described by **The Guardian** as "eclectic, eccentric and unobtrusively erudite" — piano-led jazz drawing from classical and contemporary with striking originality. From £25.

WED 5 & THU 6 AUGUST

Denny Ilett's Electric Lady Big Band

Ronnie Scott's. A 16-piece ensemble performing arrangements of **Jimi Hendrix's** entire catalogue. This sounds like it should be naff and is almost certainly transcendent. Two shows per night, 6:40pm and 9:15pm. From £40.

WEDNESDAY 12 AUGUST

Philip Lassiter

Ronnie Scott's. Trumpeter and horn arranger who played in Prince's New Power Generation. Deep, authoritative funk. Two shows. From £45.

THURSDAY 20 AUGUST

Miles Davis Centenary — BBC Proms

Royal Albert Hall. A concert marking 100 years since the birth of the greatest jazz musician who ever lived. Conductor **Miho Hazama** leads the BBC Concert Orchestra alongside trumpeter **Ambrose Akinmusire** in new arrangements drawn from *Miles Ahead*, *Porgy and Bess*, *Sketches of Spain*, and *Quiet Nights*. Broadcast on BBC TV. Book at royalalberthall.com.

MONDAY 31 AUGUST

Enchanted: Alan Menken's Music for Disney — BBC Proms

Royal Albert Hall. The music from *The Little Mermaid*, *Beauty and the Beast*, *Aladdin*, *Pocahontas*, and more. Do not pretend you don't want to go. 7pm.

JUST ANNOUNCED AT THE ROYAL ALBERT HALL

THINGS TO PUT IN THE DIARY

Events August

Music, food, drink, talks — from Ronnie Scott's to the Royal Albert Hall, via a pub in Walthamstow.

*Good music
every week
this month.*

certificates. The compound in Bamnan was one node in a network of similar facilities that have proliferated across Southeast Asia's legal grey zones — Myanmar, Cambodia, the Philippines — operated by Chinese criminal syndicates with possible ties to state intelligence.

Whether Guo herself was a spy or simply a well-placed criminal remains disputed. What is not disputed: she was convicted of human trafficking in November 2025 and sentenced to life in prison.

The Economist's Extraordinary Story this week is the full account — and it's a remarkable piece of reporting. The Alice Guo case captures something important about our moment: the way that the machinery of democratic legitimacy — an election, a mayoralty, a national ID — can be hollowed out from the inside by patient, well-resourced actors operating at a level of sophistication that conventional politics simply doesn't expect.

The story repays every minute you spend on it.

THE ECONOMIST

The Restaurant at the End of the World

Why the business model that fed us for a century is cracking up — and who is surviving.

42%

OF AMERICAN RESTAURANTS
WERE UNPROFITABLE LAST YEAR

Lenny's Apizza

HENRIETTA STREET, COVENT GARDEN, WC2 —
OPENING AUTUMN 2026

Coming soon: a cult gets a home

Lenny's began as a pop-up in a pub in Finsbury Park, serving New Haven-style pizza — "ah-beetz," the style developed by Italian immigrants in Connecticut in the early 1900s: oblong, charred, irregular, defined by tomato and pecorino with mozzarella treated as optional. It went viral, sold out every week, and has spent the past year making people in north London very happy. This autumn, it gets a permanent home on Henrietta Street, in partnership with the team behind Casa do Frango and KOL. Not open yet, but worth knowing about, and worth booking the moment reservations open.

Hon's BBQ

CRATE BREWERY, QUEEN'S YARD, HACKNEY WICK, E9

Texas meets Hong Kong, above a brewery

Man Hon Luk spent twenty years running the Vinyl Pimp record shop in east London before a poker trip to Austin changed the direction of his life entirely. He's now running Hon's BBQ above Crate Brewery, and the combination — brisket and Sichuan beef short ribs, smoked tea eggs with candied walnuts, Xi'an-style lamb shoulder, everything sold by the gram until it sells out — is exactly as good as it sounds. Funded by a crowdfund that raised £36,000 against a £20,000 target. DJ nights and BBQ classes. The kind of east London story that in ten years gets cited as an origin point.

The Barbary

WESTBOURNE GROVE, W11

A restaurant in its prime

Building a genuine canon of cooking drawn from the coastline of North Africa and Southern Europe. The main restaurant is worth booking on any given week — but this month they've launched the **Kitchen Counter Wine Dinner Series**: small, intimate evenings eating at the counter while the kitchen works around you. The first instalment (4 August, 15 seats, £150 with full Champagne pairing) collaborates with **Billecart-Salmon**, with courses matched to cuvées from Brut Réserve through to vintage. If it's sold out, get on the list for future editions.

02 / 10 — INDUSTRY REPORT

The Restaurant at the End of the World

Why the business model that fed us for a century is cracking — from The Economist's extended industry analysis.

Here is a statistic that should stop you mid-bite: 42% of American restaurants were unprofitable last year. Not struggling. Not breaking even. Unprofitable. **The Economist** ran an extended piece on the restaurant industry this week, and the argument is sweeping: the traditional restaurant — white tablecloth or checked, it doesn't much matter — is losing to a

combination of forces that are structural, not cyclical.

The problems are overlapping. Inflation pushed food costs up faster than menus could absorb. Fewer people commute, which gutted the lunch trade in city centres. The delivery-app ecosystem has created a generation of customers who know exactly what they want and don't want to leave the sofa to get it.



*They're not in the food business anymore.
They're in the memory business.*

— THE ECONOMIST, 28 JULY 2026

And then there's the competition for the evening itself: a really good home streaming setup, a sophisticated home cocktail kit, a meal kit from a chef you admire — the evening out now has to justify itself against a properly elevated stay-in. "Dinner and a movie," writes The Economist, "has to up its game to compete with Netflix and chilaquiles."

The restaurants that are surviving and thriving are doing something different. They're selling an *experience* that cannot be replicated at home: the theatre of a tasting menu, the noise and heat of a live-fire kitchen you can watch, the communal energy of a supper club where the whole room is eating the same thing at the same time.

They're finding models — counter dining, no-reservations bars, event-led evenings — that squeeze more revenue out of a small footprint. They're leaning into scarcity: if you can only get a seat at Logma's Wednesday Lates if you plan three weeks ahead, that scarcity is part of the product.

London is an interesting test case for all this. The capital's food scene remains genuinely extraordinary — this

week alone there are four-hands dinners, a Champagne house collaboration, a New Haven pizza cult getting its first permanent home. But the economics are as brutal here as anywhere. The restaurants worth watching are the ones that have understood that they're not in the food business anymore. They're in the memory business.

Where to Go in London Right Now

Five restaurants — one for every kind of night you want to have.

Logma

HAGGERSTON HIGH STREET, E8

The best Wednesday night in east London

What started as a series of sold-out dinner parties at a couple's flat has become, via pop-ups and cult supper clubs, a proper restaurant on Haggerston High Street. **Ziad Halub** and **Farsin Rabiee** bring together the cuisines of Iraq and Iran with a casual authority that makes the food feel both deeply personal and immediately revelatory: lamb and okra stew, saffron chicken with barberry rice, pastries and coffee in the mornings. Book **Logma Lates** every Wednesday — 18 seats, candlelit communal table, £65 set menu. Three weeks ahead minimum.

Ebi Wines

ROSEBERY AVENUE, EC1

The most considered wine bar in London

Raku Oda spent years as assistant head sommelier at Heston Blumenthal's The Fat Duck before opening this small, beautiful wine bar. Every detail is considered: handmade coasters, Japanese-designed cutlery, slender shelves lined with books on ceramics. The food is deliberately minimal — olives, homemade crackers, British cheese, chilled hiyashi tomatoes — because the point is the wine, and the point of the wine is Oda's ability to match you with something you didn't know you needed. Walk-ins only. Wed–Sat 5–10:30pm, Sun 3–9:30pm. Go soon.

WHERE TO GO NOW

EAT London

Five restaurants worth your time, your wallet, and three weeks' advance planning.

*Eighteen seats.
Candlelight.
Book ahead.*

SOCIAL DATA

Ageing Disgracefully

Over-55s are Britain's new problem generation — but the data tells a more unsettling story.

55+

THE NEW PROBLEM
GENERATION

Ageing Disgracefully

The **Economist**'s weekend report this week had a headline that felt like a prank: "Why people over the age of 55 are the new problem generation." But it turns out the data backs it up entirely.

Boomers are drinking more, taking more drugs, and having more casual sex — while Gen Z, that supposedly lost generation, is going to bed early, doing yoga, and taking up crochet.



The fun statistics mask something rather less fun: more substance dependency, risk-taking borne of emptiness rather than joy.

— THE ECONOMIST

The explanation, according to the Economist's reporting, isn't simply that the old guard is enjoying a final hedonistic run. The more unsettling reading is that over-55s are exhibiting signs of social disconnection — loneliness, the loss of structure that comes with retirement, the dissolution of the social networks that kept behaviour in check.

The counterpoint: Gen Z's apparent sobriety and domesticity might itself be

a form of disconnection — a retreat from a social world that feels expensive, overwhelming, and surveilled. The generation that grew up being told that everything they did online was permanent has responded by doing less. Whether this is wisdom or withering is the question.

Both generations, in different ways, seem to be struggling with a world that doesn't quite know what to do with them.

The Ballad of Jimothy

Every so often the internet collectively decides to love something completely harmless, and the result is briefly beautiful. This week's beneficiary is a raccoon named Jimothy, who lives in Seattle's Ballard neighbourhood and has, by all accounts, been going about his business there for some time.

What makes him internet-famous is his shape. Jimothy appears to have a condition called "short spine syndrome," which means his front and rear legs are very close together, giving his torso an almost perfectly spherical quality. He looks, as one commenter put it, "like a raccoon drawn by someone who had only ever heard raccoons described over the phone."



Like a raccoon drawn by someone who had only ever heard raccoons described over the phone.

— INTERNET COMMENTER, JULY 2026

On 14 July, a local named **Kiana Hall** filmed Jimothy crossing a patch of grass and climbing a staircase. The video gathered 8 million views. Then it gathered 8 million more. Seattle's city council issued a formal proclamation declaring this "Jimothy Summer." Google produced an animation. There is now a Jimothy bobblehead.

The **Seattle Times** ran an interview with wildlife officials who gently requested

that everyone stop trying to visit Jimothy in person, for both Jimothy's sake and their own (raccoons bite).

None of this resolves the actual news of the world. But Jimothy's existence — rotund, unhurried, entirely unbothered by the attention — feels like the appropriate footnote to a fairly relentless week.

SEATTLE, WA

The Ballad of Jimothy

A spherical raccoon in Ballard, Washington, restored the internet's faith in harmless things.

16M

VIEWS ON JIMOTHY'S
VIRAL CROSSING VIDEO

VARIOUS · JULY 2026

WIRED

Your Private AI Conversations

Private chats with Claude were appearing in Google search results. Here's what it means.

0

DAYS BEFORE DELETED SHARE
LINKS APPEARED ON GOOGLE

WIRED · JULY 2026

Your Private AI Conversations Are Not As Private As You Think

WIRED broke a quietly alarming story this week: private conversations with Claude, Anthropic's AI chatbot, were appearing in Google and Bing search results. Users who had shared a

chat link — perhaps to show a friend something interesting — and then deleted the link, found their conversations indexed and publicly searchable.



Privacy has to be actively built in, not assumed.

— WIRED, JULY 2026

The screwup illustrates a structural problem with the AI chatbot era: these platforms generate enormous volumes of content — conversations, threads, shared links — and the systems designed to signal to search-engine crawlers what is and isn't public are fiendishly complex to implement correctly. A misconfigured robots.txt file, an improperly scoped sharing permission, and suddenly a conversation you had about your medical symptoms or your divorce is

sitting on page two of a Google search for your name.

Anthropic has since patched the issue. But the incident raises a question worth sitting with: how much do you really know about the privacy settings on the AI tools you use daily? The default assumption — that your conversations are private because you didn't explicitly make them public — may not be as robust as it sounds. These tools are designed to share and collaborate. Privacy has to be actively built in, not assumed.

and walk home after the theatre — has its root in a January night on Pall Mall, 219 years ago.

A plaque on the south side of the street marks the spot. Most people walk past it without glancing.

The Street That Changed How We See in the Dark

The next time you walk down Pall Mall — between St James's Palace and Trafalgar Square, that grand, club-lined thoroughfare — pause for a moment and consider that on the night of 28 January 1807, this street did something no street in the world had ever done before. It turned on its gas lights.

The man responsible was a German immigrant named **Frederick Albert**

Winsor, born Friedrich Albert Winzer in Brunswick. Winsor had patented coal-gas lighting in 1804 and spent years badgering sceptical Londoners to take the idea seriously. His own house on Pall Mall became his laboratory. Then, to celebrate King George III's birthday in June of that year, he lit the entire length of the street — thirteen lamp-posts, each carrying three gas jets — and invited London to gape.



Gas changed the city's relationship with night permanently.

— THIS WEEK IN LONDON HISTORY

Gape it did. **Thomas Rowlandson**, the caricaturist, was moved to sketch the spectacle: curious Londoners clustered around the new lights, faces tilted upward, clearly unsure whether to be delighted or suspicious. Both responses were reasonable. Before gas, London after dark was a genuinely dangerous place — lanterns were expensive, candles guttered, link-boys with

torches were the only illumination in many streets.

Winsor founded the **Gas Light and Coke Company** in 1812, the world's first gas utility. Within a decade, the technology spread across Europe. By 1823, 40,000 gas lamps covered 215 miles of London's streets. The modern city — the city where night does not mean danger, where you can read on the Tube

BLOOMBERG BUSINESSWEEK

The Boom Nobody Asked For

The menopause wellness industry is worth nearly \$19 billion. So why do most women still feel like they're on their own?

\$18.74B

The Boom Nobody Asked For

The \$18.74 billion menopause wellness industry — and the question of whether it's filling a gap or exploiting one.

Walk into any upscale pharmacy and the menopause shelf has quietly colonised half the vitamins aisle. There are cooling sprays and adaptogens, libido gummies and "hormone support" blends, apps that track your hot flushes and connect you with a "menopause coach." Brands with names like Nova Relief and Minerva Wellness have raised serious money. The global menopause

wellness market is valued at \$18.74 billion this year and projected to double to nearly \$38 billion by 2035.

Which makes it odd that, according to a survey of over 15,000 women conducted last year, only 14% of them had learned about menopause from a healthcare professional. Ninety-nine percent said they wanted it included in routine health checks.



Attention without accountability. Genuine medical need, commercial energy, regulatory lag.

— BLOOMBERG BUSINESSWEEK

Those two figures should produce cognitive dissonance — or rage. We are deep into a cultural moment that **Davina McCall** effectively kickstarted with her Channel 4 documentaries: menopause is discussed, hashtagged, mainstreamed, turned into a TED talk and a supplement range. And yet the

lived experience of most women in the UK remains one of vague symptoms, inadequate appointments, and uneven access to treatments.

A major international review published last year found menopause care to be "fragmented and unequal worldwide."

1807

The Street That Changed the Dark

On 28 January 1807, Pall Mall became the first street in the world to be lit by gas. London was never the same.

219

YEARS SINCE GAS LIGHT
FIRST LIT PALL MALL

The death toll from the heat alone is still being tallied. The European mortality monitor **EuroMOMO** attributes around 10,600 excess deaths to this summer's temperatures so far — including more than 2,700 in Britain. That figure tends to disappear from the news cycle. Heat death is quiet: people die indoors, of causes attributed to the heart or lungs. The aggregate is catastrophic, but it leaves no photograph.

The EU's emergency response infrastructure — **rescEU**, a fleet of pre-positioned firefighting aircraft — has never been activated at this scale. Twenty-two planes, five helicopters, 777 firefighters drawn from twelve countries, deployed simultaneously. This is the system performing exactly as designed. It is visibly struggling.

The Economist's piece this week frames the fires not as a crisis but as a forecast — its headline calls them "just the start," and the word *start* is doing real work. Fire scientists and climate modellers are converging on a conclusion that European governments have been slow to absorb: the Mediterranean fire season now resembles what hurricane season looks like in the Atlantic. It is annual, structural, and worsening.

The question left hanging — and it is not a small one — is whether Europe's planning will ever catch up to the summers it is already living through. Building codes, land management, early-warning systems, evacuation infrastructure: all of it calibrated to a climate that no longer exists.

The NHS has just announced menopause will be added to routine health checks — a real, if long-overdue, shift — but it barely scratches the structural problem.

This is **Bloomberg Businessweek's** cover story this week, and the critique it lands is sharp: the wellness industry has rushed into the gap between women's need and the healthcare system's provision, and what it sells often resembles care without actually being it. Some of it is straightforwardly misleading. This spring, the UK's Advertising Standards Authority found that Minerva Wellness and Nova Relief had broken rules by suggesting their supplements could work like medicines — effectively positioning over-the-counter pills as alternatives to HRT. They cannot. They do not.

HRT itself — real HRT, the kind with robust clinical evidence behind it — has also been in short supply. The trigger was unexpected: in November 2025, the FDA finally removed its outdated boxed warning on menopausal

hormone therapy, the relic of a 2002 study that had unfairly frightened women and doctors away from the treatment for over two decades. The resulting demand spike was enormous. Patch use had already tripled between 2018 and early 2026; the post-FDA-reversal surge compressed years of growth into months. Manufacturing capacity was not ready.

There is something almost perfectly dark about this. After decades of being demonised and underprescribed, HRT is vindicated — and the shelves run out. Into the vacuum rushes an industry selling things that are not HRT but look, in the right lighting, a little like it. The broader pattern is one women's health knows too well: attention without accountability. The question is whether the menopause moment becomes a real turning point in how medicine treats women in midlife — or whether it turns out, like so many wellness revolutions before it, to be mostly something you can buy.

FORECAST

The Continent Is on Fire

Ten thousand dead, 330,000 evacuated, and a summer scientists say would have been virtually impossible without climate change.

10,600

EXCESS HEAT DEATHS
IN EUROPE THIS SUMMER

The Continent Is on Fire

Ten thousand dead, 330,000 evacuated — and The Economist says this is "just the start."

At the height of last month's fires, the smoke from the Gironde was visible from space. The blaze, which tore through 42,000 hectares of forest south of Bordeaux — one of the largest fires in France since the Second World War — was still burning when a new front opened west of Madrid. That fire merged with a second to form a single inferno across 80,000 hectares of

Castilian hillside: the largest in Spain's recorded history.

By 1 August, roughly 330,000 people had been forced from their homes across France and Spain alone, with fresh evacuations beginning as the crisis shifted east to Greece, where gale-force winds drove flames through a coastal resort and hundreds fled by sea. This is the summer Europe is having.

”

Portugal, Spain, France, Greece, and Turkey are not experiencing a run of bad luck. They are experiencing a new climate.

— THE ECONOMIST, 28 JULY 2026

The heatwaves that preceded the fires broke records quietly and then spectacularly. Western Europe's June ran 3.06 degrees Celsius above its recent average — not a rounding error, an epochal number. Heat scientists have been explicit: that June would

have been "virtually impossible" without human-induced climate change. And the heat is not incidental to the fires; it *is* the fires, in a different form — parched soil, dead vegetation, winds that strip moisture from everything they touch.